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ENG 300H

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8 May 2026

The Silenced

I first saw her when I was seven years old. She crept into my room in the middle of the night, a willowy thing, gaunt and nearly see-through, and placed a barely there palm onto my forehead, startling me awake. She didn't say a word to me, only leaning over my bed and watching me with dark eyes like two deep pits. Frozen with fear, that night we just stared at each other—a strange sort of staring contest—until my parents came to wake me in the morning.

For the rest of the day, I was dead on my feet yet unable to ever completely relax as she was still there, following and staring. No one else ever acknowledged her. Wherever she stood, people unconsciously seemed to move around her, forming a permanently empty spot just behind me and to the left. Whenever I tried to tell anyone about her, I watched in real time as the information seemed to just slip from their mind leaving them confused and concerned as I grew increasingly hysterical that no one was hearing me. Over time I learned to ignore her and to pretend to be like everyone else. But she was always there.

This continued on for years until a day during seventh grade. Middle school, as it is for a majority of people, was hell, and I had just had my heart broken by someone I had considered a best friend. As I hid in a grimy bathroom stall, trying and failing to stifle my sobs, I felt a coolness envelop my body. Blinking away tears, I looked up to see that the woman had taken me up into her arms, one cool hand softly swiping through my hair. It was such a slight pressure on my skin I could almost trick my brain that she wasn't really touching me, but, desperate as I was

in that moment for any type of affection, I wrapped my arms around her as my sobs picked up anew.

From that day, our relationship shifted. Clearly not that much, however, because here I was again, sobbing my eyes out into the faint cool presence of the woman who haunted me. It was nothing major that set me off this time, just one too many quiet comments or dismissals that made me want to yell and rage and break something—to rip off my skin and make them see me. Stupid, I know.

When my tears finally dried, I gently pulled myself from the woman's grip. She stared down at me, head tilted in a questioning manner. " " she asked, her mouth moving in that silent, unintelligible it always did.

I had tried many times to teach her sign language so we could actually communicate with one another, but just like how any information about her seemed to slip from other people's minds, her gaze would turn distant and any small progress we had made would fall from her mind, leaving disoriented and frustrated. I had then turned to trying to lip read for a bit, but her lack of solidity made it way too difficult for me. We had quickly learned that it just wasn't worth it and most of our "conversations" now consisted of me trying to read her body language and guessing what she was trying to convey.

I gathered she was trying to ask me what had brought upon my crying fit. I sighed. "I just really hate the people at my job. It's like I'm not even there sometimes." I collapsed onto my sofa across the room, my body and mind fully exhausted at this point but feeling much better after getting my emotions out. She watched me go, her dark eyes tracking my movements and face unreadable. What I said finally caught up in my mind and I winced, "Oops, sorry." She only stared at me a moment longer, shook her head, and then swept out of the room without a sound.

I covered my face with my hands, hissing through my teeth.

She'd be back.

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The next day, when I was once again met with a vague, dismissive finger in my face and a curt “Just a sec,” I felt the familiar rage build up in my chest before I quickly banked it, shrinking in on myself and returning to the background. Instinctively, I looked behind me to the woman, but she was not there. Frantically, I searched the room, only to find her looming behind the man who had just dismissed me. Her expression was furious—a raging wildfire within her pitch black eyes.

“

” the woman grit out. She

then lunged, plunging her fingers *into* my coworker's throat and clenching. Whatever he had been saying was abruptly cut off as he gagged. Wide-eyed, his hands fluttered around his throat then banged against his chest as he continued to try and fail to produce any meaningful sound.

I could only watch in horror as those around the man began to question if he was alright, if he was choking on something, if they should call 911. Finally regaining my own voice, I yelled at the woman. “Stop,” I cried. “What are you doing?” Everyone turned to look at me, faces incredulous, and it was only then that I realized what it must look like: me angrily yelling at a coworker to stop choking. Heat rose to my face, mortification settling over my shoulders, but the woman did stop. She removed her hands from the man's throat—the sight admittedly making me feel a little nauseous—and stared at me. Her brow was still furrowed in a rage and I could no longer tell if it was still directed towards my coworker or now onto me.

As the man could now speak, the attention of the rest of my coworkers quickly shifted off of me and back onto him. My eyes, however, stayed locked onto the woman's, a staring contest reminiscent of the night we met, but now heavy with a history I could tell the woman felt I had just betrayed. Utilizing my restored invisibility, I took the opportunity to slip from the room and out the door, not caring for the consequences or checking if the woman was following me.

I knew she was.

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As I shut the door to my apartment, I finally turned to look at the woman again and scowled. "What was that?" She opened her mouth but I interrupted, "You can't just physically assault people. I didn't even know you could do that!" She scowled back at me, but didn't try to speak this time. "Was it because of yesterday? I don't need you to fight my battles."

" " she said, crossing her arms.

I sighed, frustrated, "I don't know why you keep trying to talk to me. I think it's been well established by now that I can't understand you." I scrubbed my face and let out a deep sigh, waving my hand vaguely in her direction. "Just get out of here. I think we both need to decompress."

The woman balked a moment then stalked forward and jabbed a finger into my chest. There was no real force behind the phantom limb, but I still took a shocked step backwards. I could only watch as the woman stalked around the room, arms gesticulating wildly. I had never seen her act like this before, spitting silent words as if they were poison. "

” She paused, “ ”

and, having said her piece, the woman turned and walked straight through me and out the door.

As her cold, barely-there body phased through me, feelings of rage and despair and righteousness crashed over me in equal measure. I nearly stumbled at the weight of emotions that were not mine. No, that wasn't quite right—they might have not come from me at that moment, but they were not foreign to me. I had felt them many times throughout my life. Taught myself to ignore them, to push them away and out of my body. For that moment, I allowed myself to feel them, to let out a primal scream of pure frustration that seemed to echo throughout my whole apartment. I hoped people could hear it from outside.

I hoped the woman could hear it.

And then the emotions were gone once more. I straightened myself out, cleared my throat, and glanced behind me. She wasn't there, but I knew she'd be back.

She always was.